Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Walt Whitman's "When I Heard the Learn'd Astronomer"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of the contrast that support the theme of Walt Whitman's "When I Heard the Learn'd Astronomer" include

alliteration,	imagery,	sigmatism,
allusion,	internal rhyme,	speaker,
ambiguity,	inversion,	structure,
anaphora,	metaphor,	style,
asyndeton,	pun,	syncope,
diction,	resonance,	synecdoche,
elision,	rhopalic line,	theme, and
free verse,	setting,	tone.

The young writer in her discussion of the contrasts that inform Whitman's poem should address the poem's theme, which might itself be summed up in terms of contrast: The reduction of the mystery of the universe, as represented by the stars, to proofs and figures and represented further by diagrams and in charts (lines 2-3) fails utterly.

The contestant might argue that the very structure of the poem is a balance in contrast; he might point out that the first four lines, which are grouped through anaphora, contrast with the final four lines, which lose the structured anaphora and exhibit something toward rising, gliding, wandering (line 6).

The anecdotal tone of the speaker's description of the lecture-room contrasts with the ordered nature of such a setting in which the speaker would be sitting, essentially shackled like Plato's prisoners in the cave, until he tires of all that his fellow prisoners applaud (line 4), and he finds his way out of the lecture-room into the "mystical moist night-air" (line 7). The contrast between the imagined stentorian voice of the lecturer punctuated "with much applause" (line 4) and the silence of the open-area night should be central to the discussion.

The young writer might focus on the temporal turn that begins with line 5's "How soon unaccountable [. . .]." She might make something of the poem's diction beyond its characterizing of the poem's speaker (a contrast, certainly, with the learned nature of the lecturer). Inherent in the speaker's use of *unaccountable*, given the contrast between the figures and graphs of the poem's lecture-room and the mystical cosmos, is wordplay, specifically, a pun. She might point to the ambiguity of the phonetic quality of *heard*, which, through its implied homonym *herd*, contrasts with the solitary refuge to which the speaker escapes. A very Whitmanesque contrast is inherent in the dried-ink world of graphic representation (the charts, diagrams, etc.) and the mystical moistness (line 7) of nature.

The contestant might argue that the poem itself is, in its fullness, a metaphor that sings the praise of actually experiencing the world, much in the vein of Wordsworth impugnment of book learnin': "One impulse from a vernal wood / May teach you more [. . .]."